

ELIJAH WATSON

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Professional Summary

I am an anthropological biodemographer studying how historical and contemporary societal shocks shape local population health in social, economic, and evolutionary context.

Research Areas: developmental origins of health and disease; natural experiments and event-study designs; social epigenomics and genomics; political economy of population health; longitudinal (birth) cohorts.

Education

PhD	Biological Anthropology, Northwestern University <i>Certificates:</i> Society, Biology, and Health Management for PhDs, Northwestern Kellogg School of Management	<i>forthcoming</i> , August 2026
MPH	Epidemiology, Northwestern University, Feinberg School of Medicine	2026
MA	Anthropology, Northwestern University	2023
BA	Anthropology, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill <i>Minor:</i> Medicine, Literature, and Culture <i>Study Abroad:</i> Honors Carolina Semester in Cape Town, South Africa (2017)	2019

Awards

Grants

- **F31 Ruth L. Kirschstein Predoctoral Individual National Research Service Award (NRSA)** | (\$88,110) *2024-2026*
 - “Socioeconomic status across the life course and epigenetic age acceleration in adulthood: Evidence from two generations of a Filipino birth cohort study” (NIH/NIA: F31AG084273)
- **National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellow (GRFP)** | \$138,000 *2020*
- **UNC Frances L. Phillips Travel Scholarship:** Awarded to support travel to the Galapagos Islands and South Africa for fieldwork and experiential learning to inform future research on food and water insecurity | (\$9,500) *2019*
- **UNC Undergraduate Research Consultant Team Grant** | (\$10,000) *2019*
 - Pilot study on food and water security on Isabela Island, Galápagos (*collaboration with Universidad San Francisco de Quito & UNC Galápagos Science Center*)
- **UNC Gillian T. Cell Senior Thesis Research Grant** *2018*

Scholarships and Awards

- **E.E. Hunt, Jr. Award**, Human Biology Association, awarded for an outstanding graduate student oral presentation *2024*
- **Tuition Scholarship**, Short course on causal inference, Department of Epidemiology, Harvard T. H. Chan School of Public Health *2022*
- **Travel Award**, Interdisciplinary Association of Population Health Scientists *2022*

- **Honigmann Undergraduate Thesis Award**, UNC Dept. of Anthropology 2019
- **Travel Award**, Harvard School of Public Health, Center for Communicable Disease Dynamics, Conference to Increase Diversity in Mathematical Modeling & Public Health 2019

Publications

Peer-reviewed Manuscripts

- **Elijah Watson**, Delaney Glass, and Lucia Petito. (2025). Toward New Directions in Human Biology: A Roadmap for Anthropological Causal Inference with Observational Data. *American Journal of Human Biology*. ([link](#))
- Chihua Li, Rebecca Stebbins, Grace Noppert, Constanza Carney, Chunyu Liu, Ashley Sapp, **Elijah Watson**, and Allison Aiello. (2024). Peripheral Immune Function and Alzheimer's Disease: A Living Systematic Review and Critical Appraisal. *Molecular Psychiatry*. ([link](#))
- Margaret Butler, Britney Smart, **Elijah Watson**, Shreya Narla, and Lauren Keenan-Devlin. (2023). Breastfeeding durations differ at the intersection of race/ethnicity and educational attainment in a nationally representative sample from the US. *Journal of Human Lactation*. ([link](#))
- Melissa Manus, **Elijah Watson**., Sahana Kuthyar, Delia Carba, Nikola Belarmino, Thomas McDade, Christopher Kuzawa, and Katherine Amato. (2023). Prenatal household size and composition are associated with infant fecal bacterial diversity in Cebu, Philippines. *American Journal of Biological Anthropology*. ([link](#))
- Amanda Thompson, Khristopher Nicholas, **Elijah Watson**, Enrique Terán, and Margaret Bentley. (2019). Water, food, and the dual burden of disease in Galápagos, Ecuador. *American Journal of Human Biology*. ([link](#))

Manuscripts under Review

- Thomas W. McDade, Sofia Carrera, Calen P. Ryan, **Elijah Watson**, Linda S. Adair, Nanette R. Lee, Delia B. Carba, Julie L. MacIsaac, Kristy Dever, Michael S. Kobor, Christopher W. Kuzawa. "Chronic inflammation and multiple dimensions of aging among women in the Philippines." Revise and Resubmit at *Journals of Gerontology: Biological Sciences*.
- Delaney J. Glass, Jeffrey G. Snodgrass, Choeeta Chakrabarti, Kateryna Maltseva, Katya Xinyi Zhao, **Elijah Watson**, François Dengah, and Seth Sagstetter "Counterfactual Logic Improves Ethnographic Explanation: Bridging Anthropological and Interdisciplinary Perspectives on Causality." Submitted to *American Anthropologist*.

Conference Presentations and Invited Talks

Recent and Upcoming Talks

- **EJ Watson**, Thomas McDade, Lucia Petito, Michael Kobor, Calen Ryan, Nanette Lee, Linda Adair, and Christopher Kuzawa. "The Fetal Origins of Biological Aging: Evidence from the 1983 Philippine Economic Crisis"
 - Berkeley Formal Demography Workshop, 2025
 - Montgomery Lecture Series, Center for Medical Humanities and Bioethics, Northwestern University Feinberg School of Medicine, January 2026

- UCLA/USC Workshop on Determinants of Adult Mortality, Morbidity, and Healthy Aging in LMICs, March 2026
- Colloquium Talk, Department of Data and Decision Sciences, Emory University, April 2026
- Population Association of America, May 2026
- The Advances in Social Genomics Conference, University of Wisconsin-Madison, May 2026
- 11th International Conference of the Evolutionary Demography Society, Colorado State University, June 2026

Oral Presentations

- **EJ Watson**, Delaney Glass, Lucia Petito. “Toward New Directions in Human Biology: A Roadmap for Causal Inference with Observational Data.” Human Biology Association. Baltimore, MD. 2025
- **EJ Watson**. “It’s Biomedical Standard Time somewhere: Epigenetic clocks as a causal mechanism linking social and environmental exposures to health.” *EpiCause 2024: Causality in Epidemiology* meeting at the Institute of Philosophy and Scientific Method. Johannes Kepler University of Linz, Austria. 2024
- **EJ Watson**, TW McDade, CP Ryan, NR Lee, JL MacIsaac, K Dever, P Atashzay, MS Kobor, CW Kuzawa. “Evaluating the convergent and predictive validity of epigenetic age acceleration measured from common epigenetic clocks in Cebu, Philippines.” Human Biology Association. Los Angeles, CA. (Awarded the E.E. Hunt, Jr. Student Award for Outstanding Podium Presentation). 2024

Panels, Guest Lectures, and Workshops

- “Causal Inference with Observational Data,” Guest lecture, University of Toronto, Department of Anthropology. *October 2025*.
- “Statistical versus causal inference.” (Remote). Invited panelist for a round table discussion hosted by the Frontiers in Social Evolution (FINE) Seminar. 2022
- “A primer on using directed acyclic graphs for causal inference.” Workshop presentation for Northwestern’s Evolutionary & Ecological Approaches to Health research group meeting. 2022

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record, Northwestern University, Evanston, IL

2025-Present

- **“Climate Change and Sustainability in Health Care”** – Winter 2025 & 2026
 - Co-designed NU’s first medical school elective on climate and sustainability
 - Elective seminar for (10) first year medical students
 - Coordinated and facilitated seminars; lectured for 2 out of 5 sessions

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University Evanston, IL

- **“Intermediate Epidemiology”** | BIOSTAT 401 2023
 - Developed and gave lecture on Causal Inference with Directed Acyclic Graphs
- **“Introduction to Epidemiology”** | BIOSTAT 301 2023

- **“The Social Determinants of Health”** | Global Health 222 2023
- **"Introduction to Global Health"** | Public Health/Global Health 390 2022

Workshop Instructor, Northwestern University Evanston, IL

- **R for Social Data Science** 2024
 - Designed and led a 5-session workshop (4–5 attendees weekly) on reproducible data science (R, tidyverse, RStudio, Quarto, GitHub).

Mentorship

Silas Colombara, Undergraduate Research Mentee 2023 – 2024

- “Childhood Household Wealth Trajectories and Adult Mental Health in the Cebu Longitudinal Health and Nutrition Survey”

Other Research Experience

Field Researcher

- **UNC Center for Galápagos Studies & Galápagos Science Center** Isabela Island, Galapagos 2019

Internships

- **Carolina Population Center.** UNC Chapel Hill 2018
- **Scalabrini Centre of Cape Town, South Africa** 2017
 - Refugee/Migrant Employment Access Programme Intern

Research Assistantships

- **UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health, Department of Epidemiology** 2018

Op-eds

- “Opinion: Climate studies, National Institutes of Health Under Attack” [Asheville Citizen Times](#) 2025

Service and Outreach

- **Northwestern Feinberg School of Medicine, Program in Public Health**
 - Curriculum Committee 2025 – Present
- **Interdisciplinary Association for Population Health Science**
 - Student Committee, Webinar Co-Chair 2023 – 2025
- **Boys & Girls Clubs of Chicago / Northwestern Science in Society Program**
 - Science Club Mentor, Pedersen-McCormick Boys & Girls Club 2023 – 2024

Professional Society Memberships

Population Association of America; Interdisciplinary Association for Population Health Science; Human Biology Association; Evolutionary Demography Society

Additional Training

Workshops and Short Courses

- **Berkeley Workshop in Formal Demography**, University of California, Berkeley 2025
- **Causal Inference with Time-Varying Exposures**, Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop 2023
- **Introduction to Parametric and Semi-parametric Estimators for Causal Inference**, Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop 2023
- **Writing Reproducible Research in R with Quarto**, Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop 2023
- **Key Topics in Causal Inference**, CAUSALab, Department of Epidemiology, Harvard T. H. Chan School of Public Health 2022
- **Mixtape Sessions: Causal Inference**, taught by Dr. Scott Cunningham 2022